A reliable source in the know says the ashram needs professionals to handle everyday functioning so that visitors get more than just a brick-and-mortar experience. The Gandhi Heritage Portal, for instance, a benchmark project of the ashram and the government that boasts the biggest repository of resources on Gandhi, has not had a full-time editor for six years. "The portal is the interface for millions who access it virtually every day. Such things should be addressed professionally," the source says.



"For almost all of the past decade, the state has withheld maintenance funds on one pretext or another. Maintaining the campus and paying staff salaries was impossible"

–MANDA PARIKH
Former trustee, Gujarat Vidyapith

BATTLE FOR THE VIDYAPITH

Meanwhile, three kilometres from the ashram, controversy is brewing at another Gandhian institution, the Gujarat Vidyapith. Last year, two days after the Mahatma's 153rd birth anniversary, Gujarat Governor Acharya Devvrat was invited by the institute to take over as chancellor after Ela Bhatt resigned on health grounds. Since then, nine of the institute's 24 trustees have resigned in protest over the decision to appoint a 'non-Gandhian' for the post, alleging that the government was intent on "taking over big, small, strong and weak Gandhian institutions and thereby erase and alter history (sic)". However, if the trustees had hoped their resignation would trigger a rethink, the opposite happened. Of the six people appointed in January and April to fill the posts vacated by the protesters, at least two are from the BJP.

The controversy at Vidyapith, in fact, dates back to 2020 when Rajendra Khimani was appointed vice-chancellor and it turned out that the selection committee did not have the mandatory representative from the University Grants Commission (UGC). The panel was then reconstituted with a UGC nominee, who reportedly rejected Khimani's candidature. Separately, the commission had even launched an inquiry into financial irregularities and appointments when Khimani was registrar between 2004 and 2019. His run as V-C came to an end this January after he resigned following a Gujarat HC order directing the university to take a decision on the issue.

END OF THE CONTROVERSY?

No, the beginning of another. Many are now treating Devvrat's appointment beyond his ex officio remit as Chancellor of all state universities, as much more damaging, though he is not the first political figure to hold the post. Gandhi was the lifetime Chancellor of the Vidyapith from 1920 to 1948, followed by the likes of Vallabhbhai Patel, Dr Rajendra Prasad, Morarji Desai, and Prof. Ramlal Parikh, who was a Rajya Sabha member representing the Janata Party. Navin Chandra Barot, the Chancellor in 2001-02, too, was a Janata Party politician and minister. In fact, in 2007, Gandhi's grandson Gopalkrishna Gandhi refused to take up the chancellorship offered to him after concerns were raised that he did not wear Khadi at all times. Unlike Devvrat, all the previous chancellors were self-professed Gandhians. Not just that, Devvrat represents a government that is seen as sympathetic to Gandhi's killer Nathuram Godse.

Devvrat's appointment also goes against the Gandhian principle of 'trusteeship', the protesters contend. "The original constitution that Gandhiji formulated for Gujarat Vidyapith stipulated that it would not accept government grants," the trustees' statement reads. It adds, "However, to bring its courses into alignment with officially recognised courses, Vidyapith acceded to UGC rules in 1963 on the condition that the government would not interfere with its autonomy. Vidyapith is now completely dependent on government grants.... It is absolutely imperative that all educational institutions, even if they receive government grants, remain independent and insulated from the rough and tumble of power and politics. Acting as the government's amplifier would be the death knell of its meaningful role in society." Says Manda Parikh, a trustee who quit, "For almost all of the past decade, the state government has not released maintenance funds under one pretext or another. Maintaining the sprawling campus and paying the staff salaries was next to impossible."

JUST ANOTHER BUILDING?

The politics around them aside, many are asking if mere buildings embody Gandhi's ideals. Perhaps not, says Rajni Bakshi, author and founder of Ahimsa Conversations, a platform that promotes the Gandhian principle of non-violence. "Non-violence and truth are not vested in a building, garden or jungle. Gandhi lives as a potential within us," she says. But, she adds, "It is also true that memories and values we associate with certain places are precious and touch us with a sense of the sacred.... This is why the ashram is important—it reminds us that it is possible to diligently live the values of non-violence, compassion and a love that transcends religious divides." Speaking of the Vidyapith row, another Gandhian scholar says: "The strength of a Gandhian institute is in how it runs itself. The ideological genealogy of individuals is not the only concern. The onus is now on existing trustees to uphold Gandhi's legacy."

At the ashram, an understated gallery houses hundreds of pictures of some of the most iconic moments in Gandhi's life. It gets its title from what Gandhi told a journalist once: "My life is my message." It may be time perhaps to heed Bapu's words. ■